AJP Policy Document

Humane management of introduced species

AJP recognises that animals from both native and introduced species are sentient, and have rights to life and welfare. AJP further recognises that humans are responsible for the introduction of non-endemic species to Aotearoa, and as such it is our responsibility to implement the most compassionate solutions where such species pose ecological threats. These should be framed and carried out in the spirit of Te Tiriti o Waitangi.

AJP supports valuing individual animals because they are sentient, not because of their species status as native or non-native. We oppose the demonisation of introduced species, and promote an understanding of them as animals living here as the direct result of human actions. With this in mind, AJP will work to raise awareness of the cruelty of current methods of controlling introduced species.

At the same time, AJP recognises the threat that particular introduced species, alongside habitat destruction and ecological damage caused by humans, pose to our native ecosystems. AJP therefore advocates for humane methods of population control, and the redirection of funds from current 'pest control' initiatives, such as Predator Free NZ,[1] towards research and development of nonviolent forms of population control, such as contraceptives. We acknowledge that new compassionate approaches to conservation are likely to impose additional costs, and that greater funding for the Department of Conservation and Ministry for the Environment are likely to be needed.[2]

AJP will also advocate for ongoing review of the goals, objectives and methodologies of the government's overarching conservation/biodiversity positions and programmes, including definitions of key terms and cost-benefit analyses of different strategies.

---

[1] https://predatorfreenz.org/about-us/predator-free-2050/predator-free-2050-vision/

[2] More humane methods already exist, but are not used due to their increased cost. See Beausoleil, N. J., Fisher, P., Warburton, B., & Mellor, D. J. (2010). *How humane are our pest control tools? Part 1: Vertebrate toxic agents and kill traps in mammal species* (MAF Biosecurity New Zealand Technical Paper 2011/01). Wellington: MAFBNZ; Parliamentary Commissioner for the Environment. (2011). *Evaluating the use of 1080: Predators, poisons and silent forests*. Wellington: PCE.

Key Objectives:

1. Call for government and government-funded entities to cease the use of unscientific, emotive and vilifying terms (e.g. ‘pests’) to describe animals and the requisite amendments made to the Animal Welfare Act.
2. Establish higher welfare standards for population control methods.
3. Fund research into nonviolent alternatives to current methods of population control.
4. Create a special task force to plan the phasing out of violent population control methods and work alongside environmental protection agencies to implement humane management of all species, endemic and introduced. This group would be responsible for developing policies that prioritise humane alternatives while balancing ecological concerns.
5. Implement educational programmes in schools, universities, and communities to promote compassionate management of introduced species.
   See: *Compassionate Education policy.*